

Youth Action Conference — Minor Engagement & Safeguarding Policy

Last updated: August 2026

The **Youth Action Conference (YAC)** is a youth-centered international event. Participants may include people under the age of 18, alongside adult participants, speakers, facilitators, volunteers, and organizers.

YAC wants young people to be able to **participate, contribute, lead, question, debate, and connect** while maintaining appropriate safeguards and boundaries.

This policy establishes expectations for anyone interacting with participants under 18 through YAC.

1. Who This Policy Applies To

For this policy, a **minor** means a participant who is under 18 years old.

The policy applies to:

- YAC organizers and volunteers
- Speakers and guest contributors
- Moderators and facilitators
- Adult participants
- Partner representatives
- Photographers or media contributors
- Anyone given an official role or access to YAC participants

It applies to YAC-hosted online sessions, breakout rooms, messaging, email, collaborative spaces, social activities, and other official YAC communications.

2. Our Safeguarding Principles

YAC will aim to:

Put young people's safety first.

The wellbeing of a minor takes priority when there is a credible safeguarding concern.

Respect young people's agency.

Being under 18 does not mean a participant's ideas, opinions, or contributions should be treated as less valuable.

Collect only necessary information.

YAC should not collect sensitive information about minors without a clear reason.

Maintain appropriate boundaries.

Adults and people in positions of responsibility must maintain professional, transparent relationships with minors.

Make reporting accessible.

Young participants should know whom they can contact if something makes them uncomfortable or concerned.

Avoid unnecessary one-to-one interactions.

Official communication should generally occur in observable YAC spaces.

3. Registration of Minors

YAC should clearly identify when a registered participant is under 18 so that appropriate safeguards can be applied.

Registration should collect only information reasonably necessary to operate the conference.

YAC should avoid requesting unnecessary information such as a minor's:

- exact home address;
- personal telephone number;
- exact date of birth, unless genuinely necessary;
- personal social-media accounts;
- medical diagnosis;
- identification documents.

Where parental or guardian consent is legally or operationally required, it should be obtained through an appropriate process.

Consent requirements may differ depending on the participant's age, location, activity, and the way personal information is being used.

4. Communication With Minors

Communication between YAC representatives and minors should be **professional, relevant to YAC, and as transparent as reasonably possible.**

Whenever practical:

- use official YAC email addresses and communication channels;
- use group communication rather than private one-to-one messaging;
- keep communication focused on conference activities;
- avoid disappearing-message platforms;
- do not move conversations unnecessarily to personal social-media accounts;
- retain appropriate organizational visibility over official communications.

Adults should not develop secretive or unnecessarily private communication channels with minors they meet through YAC.

One-to-one communication

Sometimes individual communication may be necessary—for example, responding to an accessibility request, helping a speaker prepare, or addressing a safeguarding concern.

When this happens, the interaction should:

- have a legitimate YAC purpose;
- remain professional;
- take place through an appropriate channel;
- involve another responsible organizer where appropriate;
- contain only information necessary for that purpose.

A young person should never be told to keep ordinary YAC communication secret from their parent, guardian, or another trusted adult.

5. Online Sessions

YAC should design online sessions with minors in mind.

Where practical:

- at least two responsible YAC team members should have access to participant-facing live spaces;
- breakout rooms involving minors should have appropriate moderation arrangements;
- moderators should be able to enter breakout rooms;
- participants should have a clear way to request help;
- waiting rooms, registration, or equivalent access controls should be used;
- meeting links should not be posted publicly;
- disruptive participants should be removable;
- private messaging functionality should be limited where appropriate.

Minors should not ordinarily be placed into a private one-to-one online room with an unrelated adult.

6. Cameras & Participation

Minors should **not normally be required to keep their camera on** simply to prove participation.

Participants may need or prefer to:

- turn their camera off;
- use chat rather than speaking;
- use captions;
- take breaks;
- leave and rejoin;
- participate primarily by listening;
- use another reasonable accessibility adjustment.

A young person should not be pressured to explain a disability, diagnosis, personal circumstance, or other private reason for a reasonable participation adjustment.

7. Appropriate Adult–Minor Boundaries

Adults interacting with minors through YAC must not:

- pursue romantic or sexual relationships with minors;
- engage in sexualized conversation;
- make sexual comments or jokes directed toward minors;
- request or send sexual or intimate images;
- engage in grooming behavior;
- ask a minor to keep their relationship or communications secret;
- unnecessarily request personal contact information;
- pressure a minor to move communication onto private platforms;
- arrange inappropriate private meetings;
- offer gifts, money, employment, travel, or opportunities in exchange for personal attention or secrecy;
- exploit their role, reputation, age, or authority to influence a young participant.

These expectations apply regardless of who initiates an interaction.

Adults are responsible for maintaining appropriate boundaries.

8. Participant-to-Participant Interaction

YAC encourages young people to connect with one another, but participation in the same conference does not automatically mean that everyone should exchange private contact information.

Participants should decide for themselves whether they want to stay in contact.

YAC should not publish participant email addresses, telephone numbers, social-media accounts, or other contact information in a participant directory without appropriate permission.

Where networking activities are provided, official YAC spaces are preferable.

9. Speakers, Mentors & Facilitators

Invited adults and older youth in positions of responsibility must understand that their role creates a **position of trust**.

They should:

- keep interactions related to legitimate conference purposes;
- avoid favoritism;
- avoid creating exclusive or secret relationships;
- avoid pressuring young people to share personal experiences;
- respect participants' boundaries;
- refer safeguarding concerns to the designated YAC contact.

Being an invited speaker, prominent individual, partner, sponsor, or organizer does not provide greater freedom to bypass these expectations.

10. Sensitive Discussions

YAC may discuss human rights, discrimination, conflict, health, inequality, political systems, and other challenging subjects.

Facilitators should consider the age and maturity of participants when planning these discussions.

Where appropriate:

- give advance notice of particularly sensitive material;
- avoid unnecessarily graphic content;
- allow participants to step away;
- do not require participants to disclose personal experiences;
- provide alternative ways to participate;
- remind participants where they can seek support.

A conference discussion should never become an informal interrogation of a young person's trauma or personal circumstances.

11. Recording, Photography & Screenshots

Minors require particular care when conference material may be shared publicly.

YAC should clearly communicate:

- whether a session is being recorded;
- why it is being recorded;
- where recordings or images may appear;
- whether names will be associated with them.

Appropriate consent should be obtained where required.

A participant's consent to **attend YAC** should not automatically be treated as consent to **publicly use their image**.

Participants must not independently photograph, screenshot, or record minors in violation of YAC's Code of Conduct.

12. Personal Information

Information identifying minors should only be accessible to people who genuinely need it.

Particular care should be taken with information relating to:

- accessibility or support needs;
- parent/guardian details;
- safeguarding concerns;
- private communications;
- age;
- personal circumstances.

Information should be handled according to the **YAC Privacy Policy**.

13. Parent & Guardian Information

Where appropriate, YAC should provide parents and guardians with accessible information about:

- what YAC is;
- when it takes place;
- which online platforms are used;
- what participation involves;
- recording and media practices;
- how young people can report concerns;
- how parents or guardians can contact organizers.

For younger participants, YAC may require additional guardian involvement depending on the activity and applicable requirements.

14. If a Young Person Shares a Concern

If a minor tells a YAC representative that they feel unsafe or describes a possible safeguarding concern:

Listen.

Give them space to explain in their own words.

Take it seriously.

Do not dismiss the concern or immediately challenge their account.

Do not promise absolute confidentiality.

Explain that information may need to be shared with someone who can help keep them safe.

Do not investigate.

Ask only what is reasonably necessary to understand whether immediate help is needed.

Record appropriately.

Keep an accurate, factual record where required.

Report.

Pass the concern promptly to the designated YAC safeguarding lead.

If someone appears to be in immediate danger, appropriate emergency or safeguarding services may need to be contacted.

15. Reporting a Concern

Participants, parents, speakers, and organizers should be able to report concerns to:

YAC Safeguarding Lead

Jules Kitto-Astrop

Safeguarding email

juleskittoastrop@gmail.com

During the conference

Contact any YAC moderator and ask to speak privately with the Safeguarding Lead.

YAC should identify **at least one named adult safeguarding lead** before accepting minor participants.

Where possible, a second adult should be designated as an alternative contact.

16. Concerns About a YAC Organizer

Young people must also have a way to report concerns **about the people responsible for YAC**.

If a concern involves the Safeguarding Lead, it should be possible to report it to:

Alternative Safeguarding Contact

Katarina Bekovic

katarinabekovic03@gmail.com

The person who is the subject of a safeguarding allegation should not be responsible for deciding how that allegation is handled.

17. Responding to Safeguarding Concerns

Depending on the situation, YAC may need to:

- remove someone from a session;
- restrict communication privileges;
- suspend participation;
- preserve relevant records;
- contact a parent or guardian where appropriate;
- contact a responsible organization;
- contact a platform provider;
- seek specialist safeguarding advice;
- report a concern to appropriate authorities where required.

YAC should not attempt to conduct its own criminal investigation.

The immediate priority is **safety and appropriate referral**.

18. Breaches of This Policy

A breach may result in:

REMINDER → WARNING → RESTRICTION → REMOVAL → ESCALATION

Serious concerns may result in immediate removal or escalation without following every preceding stage.

Safeguarding decisions should prioritize participant safety over someone's status as a speaker, organizer, partner, sponsor, or guest.

19. Responsibilities of the YAC Team

Before the conference, YAC should:

- appoint a named adult Safeguarding Lead;
- appoint an alternative contact;
- establish a reporting process;
- brief moderators and speakers on this policy;
- configure online-platform safety settings;
- identify which participants are minors without unnecessarily publicizing that information;
- establish appropriate recording procedures;
- establish how emergencies or serious disclosures will be escalated;
- ensure organizers know what **not** to do when receiving a safeguarding disclosure.

20. Our Commitment

Young people should not have to choose between **being protected** and **being heard**.

YAC aims to create an environment where minors can participate as genuine contributors while adults and organizers take responsibility for maintaining appropriate safeguards.

Protect young people. Respect their agency. Maintain clear boundaries. Speak up when something isn't right.